THE CLUB

by Molly Baz

Houston's Emerald Kale Salad

SERVES: 4 AS AN APPETIZER, 2 AS A MAIN

Everybody has a favorite restaurant; Houston's is mine. No, it's not led by a James Beard award-winning chef, no, it's not on the Eater hot list. It's a chain. And a perfect one at that. When I go out to dinner, I look for two things: consistently good food (never a flop), and truly impeccable vibes. Houston's has both in spades. One of my favorite items on their menu is the Emerald Kale Salad, served piled very high, and studded with roasted peanuts, herbs, scallions and Parmigiano Reggiano. If you want it as a main, you can add rotisserie chicken (that's always an option here too!). It has an addictive, sweet, acidic dressing that is inherently nutty thanks to roasted peanut oil–an oil I had never before given the time of day until I realized it was in this dressing. It's very different from regular peanut oil, which has very little flavor, and is very worth seeking out. I've eaten it so many times that I decided it was high time to figure out exactly what's in it. So that's what I did. You can see in the photo I used curly kale - for extra crunch and texture - but feel free to use lacinato if you want to make one exactly like Houston's. To those of you who cannot access a Hillstone group restaurant, this one's for you.

ACTIVE + TOTAL TIME: 35 MINS

PRODUCE

- 6 small sprigs of thyme
- ½ Serrano chile
- 3 Scallions
- 8 oz Napa Cabbage
- 12 ounces curly or lacinato kale (1-2 bunches)
- 2 big handfuls mint leaves
- 1 big handful cilantro leaves

PANTRY

- ⅓ cup unseasoned rice vinegar, plus more as needed
- 1 tbsp Soy sauce
- 2 tablespoons sugar
- 1 tablespoon spicy brown mustard (such as Gulden's)
- ⅔ cup roasted peanut oil
- Kosher salt, and freshly ground black pepper
- 1 cup roasted salted peanuts, plus more for garnish

DAIRY

- 2 oz grated parmigiano reggiano

1. MAKE THE DRESSING:

- In a large bowl, whisk to combine ⅓ cup unseasoned rice vinegar, 1 tablespoon low-sodium soy sauce, 2 tablespoons sugar, 1 tablespoon spicy brown mustard, and the leaves of 6 small sprigs of thyme. Finely chop ½ a serrano chile and stir in.
- Working slowly, whisk in ⅔ cup roasted peanut oil until thick and emulsified. Season the dressing with salt and pepper.

2. PREP THE SALAD:

- Start slicing and adding everything to the bowl:
- Thinly slice 3 scallions and 8 oz napa cabbage. De-stem 1 8-oz bunch of curly kale and tear it into bite-sized pieces, adding to the bowl as you go.
- Pluck the leaves of a big handful of mint and cilantro, adding to the bowl. Finally, smash 1 cup roasted salted peanuts and add about ⅔ of them in.
- Toss everything very well, seasoning with salt and pepper, and working until everything is well coated in the dressing. Add more vinegar as needed until it tastes really bright and nice. Lastly, sprinkle over 2 ounces grated Parmigiano Reggiano and toss once more.

3. SERVE:

- Serve, sprinkled with more parm and peanuts, piled high as can be on a plate!

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